

SIKH RAHIT MARIĀDĀ

The original *Rahit* was verbally communicated by the Tenth Prophet, Gurū Gobind Singh, to the Five Beloved Ones on the Vaisākhī Day in 1699. Following that event, the *rahit* was primarily transmitted orally. During the eighteenth century, some individuals wrote down what they understood of the *rahit*. These written versions are ascribed to Bhāi Nand Lāl, Bhāi Desā Singh, Bhāi DaJā Singh, Caupā Singh, among others. None of these written versions, however, seem to have comprehensively captured the original verbal communication to the Five Beloved Ones. It could also be that over the years, the original versions of Bhāi Nand Lāl's *rahit* or the *rahit* written by others were altered. Caupā Singh's *rahit* is problematic because Caupā Singh was a Chibbar Brahmin, and he has chosen to write the *rahit* according to his ideas and not those of the Gurū. For instance, Caupā Singh says that Brahmins should be considered supreme or that women should never be trusted. So, all existing written *rahits* seem to be unsatisfactory for one reason or another.

After the Gurū, one person, in any case, cannot document the *rahit*. The Gurū transferred his authority to the Gurū Panth and the Gurū Granth. So it is the Panth, the collective of all committed Sikhs, who have the authority to draft the *rahit* in light of the teachings of the Gurū Granth. This would mean building a consensus among all the members of the Panth, which may seem to be a tall order for our community.

Through the eighteenth and nineteenth century, however, such consensus did exist. The Khālsā would assemble at the Ak āl Takht, or elsewhere when the Takht was inaccessible and make decisions for the Panth through consensus. We have at least one eye witness account from 1805 when John Malcolm was present at a Sarbat Kh ālsā in Amritsar. The *rahit* during these years was never disputed and it remained an oral tradition, although disputes on the correct code of conduct starting becoming prevalent. The debate on meat, for instance, seems to have started as early as the middle of the eighteenth century, about fifty years after the passing of Gurū Gobind Singh. But such debates never became the focus of the Khālsā's attention, as there were other more significant issues to deal with.

By the end of the 19th century, the *rahit* Sikhs practiced had deteriorated so much that the Sikh identity was pretty much lost. As with the Buddhists, the Sikhs had been engulfed into the larger Hindu fold. This was partly due to the Hindu or Aryan approach towards undermining and swallowing up any Indic creeds that sought to assert a separate identity and challenge the Hindu caste structure. The other reason was the Sikhs were complacent about their practices and identity. In the later half of the 19th century, Sikhs woke up and several reform movements started that sought to revive the original intent of the ten Sikh Prophets. One of these movements was the Singh Sabhā *lahir*. These movements also addressed the issue of the community not having a uniform *rahit*.

In 1925, after much debate and discussion, a *rahit* was drafted by scholars from several differing schools of Sikh thought. This draft *rahit* was then sent to Sikhs all over the world. This was a serious attempt at building consensus among the community. Principal Tejā Singh was convener of this effort. Other people involved in this effort included notable Sikhs such as Bhāī Vīr Singh, Akālī Kaur Singh and Bhāī Kāhn Singh Nābhā. So serious were these Sikhs about hearing from Sikhs worldwide, they sent this draft to Canada, USA, Kenya, Malaysia and other Diaspora countries. Remember this was 1920s, when air travel did not exist. After eleven years of debate and discussion, during which some Sikhs chose to walk out of the process because they did not get their way, a final version was agreed to in 1936. This version is what most mainstream Sikhs accept as the Gurū Panth's *rahit*. Some Sikhs revere this document because it reflects the closest Sikhs have come to a consensus in a long time. *Rahits* written by individuals, regardless of how great their practice of Sikhī, still remain the ideas of just individuals. Bhāī Randhīr Singh, Bābā Gurbachan Singh Bhindranāla and other such Sikhs were no doubt devoted Sikhs, but were not the Gurū, and cannot speak for the Gurū Panth. Their ideas are those of individuals, and their *rahits* are not any more acceptable than those of Caupā Singh or Desā Singh.

The Gurū Panth's *Rahit*, therefore, is the 1936 version accepted by the SGPC in 1945 and other Sikh institutions. Note that this *rahit* is not the SGPC's *rahit*; it is the Panth's *rahit*. The SGPC is one organization that accepts and prints this *rahit*. Other smaller organizations such as the Sikh Missionary College also print this *rahit*. This *rahit* has seen three small changes in the 1940s (the addition of eventual hope of Sikhs to freely visit shrines in Pakistan), 1960s (the addition of a fifth Takht) and 1990s (the addition of reading the complete Anand Sāhib during *Ammrit Sancār* instead of 6 *paKrls*). No one, including the Jathedār of Akāl Takht, has the authority to amend this document. If the Panth is to see any form of unity today, it is imperative that they rally around this *marīā dā*, until we can be free to come up with something better. We would encourage all Sikhs to read and live by *Rahit's* letter and spirit.

Vāhgurū jī kā Khālsā, Vāhgurū jī kī Phatah!